Oracle DBA & SQL Server DBA

Interview Preparation Guide

Mid-Level Role | Complete 2-Day Study Pack

Beginner-Friendly | Simple Language | Scenario-Based Answers

Topics Covered:

Oracle Architecture | Backup & Recovery | RMAN | Data Guard | RAC
User Management | Tablespaces | Indexing | Performance Tuning
SQL Server DBA Basics | High Availability | Patching | Troubleshooting

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How to Use This Guide

This document is designed for complete beginners preparing for a Mid-Level Oracle DBA / SQL Server DBA interview in just 2 days. Follow the plan below:

2-Day Study Plan

Day	Morning (3–4 hrs)	Evening (2–3 hrs)
Day 1	Sections 1–6: Oracle Basics, Architecture, Users, Tablespaces, Backup & Recovery, RMAN	Sections 7–9: Data Guard, RAC, Indexing + Quick Revision
Day 2	Sections 10–13: Performance Tuning, SQL Server DBA, SQL Queries, Patching	Sections 14–15: HA, Scenario-Based Q&A + Final Revision

📝 *Each Q&A box = one question. Read Q first, try to answer in your head, then read A.*

💡 *Items marked ⭐ IMPORTANT are the most likely to appear in your interview. Focus on these first.*

🧠 **Memory Trick: Read the 'Key Points / Summary' boxes aloud before sleeping each night. It improves retention.**

SECTION 1: Oracle DBA Basics

Think of a Database Administrator (DBA) as the caretaker of all data in a company. Just like a librarian organizes and protects books, a DBA organizes and protects the company's data stored in the database.

⭐ **IMPORTANT: These foundational questions appear in almost every Oracle DBA interview.**

1.1 What is Oracle DBA? — Core Q&A

Q: What is an Oracle Database and what does a DBA do?

A: An Oracle Database is software made by Oracle Corporation that stores, organizes, and manages data. A DBA (Database Administrator) is the person responsible for installing, maintaining, securing, tuning, and backing up the database. Daily tasks include creating users, managing storage space, taking backups, fixing performance problems, and keeping the database running 24/7.

Q: What are the main responsibilities of an Oracle DBA?

A: 1) Installation and configuration of Oracle software. 2) Creating and managing user accounts and their permissions. 3) Managing tablespaces and storage. 4) Taking backups regularly and doing recovery when needed. 5) Monitoring database performance. 6) Applying patches and upgrades. 7) Implementing high availability (Data Guard, RAC). 8) Writing and optimizing SQL queries. 9) Troubleshooting issues reported by application teams.

1.2 Oracle Architecture — The Building Blocks

Before the interview, you must understand how Oracle works internally. Think of Oracle as a big office building:

- The BUILDING = The Database (files stored on disk)
- The WORKERS inside = Background Processes (they do the work)
- The OFFICE SPACE = Memory (SGA + PGA)

Q: What is the Oracle Instance and how is it different from an Oracle Database?

A: An Oracle INSTANCE is the combination of memory (SGA) and background processes that run in the server. Think of the instance as the 'engine' of the car. The DATABASE is the actual data stored in files on the hard disk — like the 'fuel' in the tank. You need both to run. When Oracle starts, it creates the instance first, then attaches it to the database.

Q: What is SGA and what are its main components?

A: SGA stands for System Global Area. It is the shared memory area used by Oracle. Simple analogy: SGA is like the RAM of your phone — it stores things temporarily for fast access. Main components: 1) Database Buffer Cache — stores recently used data blocks from disk. 2) Shared Pool — stores recently run SQL statements and their execution plans. 3) Redo Log Buffer — stores transaction changes before they go to redo log files. 4) Large Pool — used for RMAN backups and parallel operations.

Q: What is the difference between SGA and PGA?

A: SGA (System Global Area) is shared memory — all users and processes share it. PGA (Program Global Area) is private memory — each user session has its own PGA. SGA is created when the instance starts. PGA is created when a new user connects. Example: If 100 users are connected, there is 1 SGA but 100 PGAs.

Q: What are the main background processes in Oracle? Name at least 5.

A: 1) DBWR (Database Writer) — Writes data from Buffer Cache to data files on disk. 2) LGWR (Log Writer) — Writes from Redo Log Buffer to redo log files. 3) SMON (System Monitor) — Does crash recovery automatically when database restarts after failure. 4) PMON (Process Monitor) — Cleans up failed user connections. 5) CKPT (Checkpoint) — Signals DBWR to write dirty blocks and updates control files. 6) ARCn (Archiver) — Copies filled redo logs to archive area (when in ARCHIVELOG mode).

🧠 **Memory Trick: Background Process Memory Trick: 'D-L-S-P-C-A' = DBWR, LGWR, SMON, PMON, CKPT, ARCn. Remember: 'Don't Let Students Play Computer Always'**

1.3 Physical and Logical Structure

Q: What are the physical files of an Oracle Database?

A: Oracle has 3 main physical files: 1) Data Files (.dbf) — These store all your actual data (tables, indexes, etc.). 2) Redo Log Files — These record every change made to the database. They are like a diary of all transactions. 3) Control Files — These are small but very important files that store the database name, location of data files, and backup history. Losing all control files = big problem. Also: SPFILE/PFILE (parameter files), Password File, Archive Log Files.

Q: What is the logical structure of an Oracle Database? Explain from largest to smallest.

A: Oracle stores data logically in this hierarchy (largest to smallest): 1) DATABASE — Contains everything. 2) TABLESPACE — A logical container inside the database (like a

folder). 3) SEGMENT — Space used by one object (e.g., one table or one index). 4) EXTENT — A group of consecutive data blocks assigned to a segment. 5) DATA BLOCK — The smallest unit Oracle reads/writes (like one page in a book). Memory Trick: 'Database Tablespace Segment Extent Block' = 'Doctors Take Some Extra Breaks'

🧠 **Memory Trick: Physical = files on disk (Data, Redo, Control). Logical = inside Oracle (Tablespace > Segment > Extent > Block).**

✔ Oracle = Instance (Memory + Processes) + Database (Files on Disk)
✔ SGA is shared memory; PGA is private per-session memory
✔ 3 physical files: Data Files, Redo Log Files, Control Files
✔ Logical hierarchy: Database > Tablespace > Segment > Extent > Block
✔ Key background processes: DBWR, LGWR, SMON, PMON, CKPT, ARCn

SECTION 2: Tablespaces & Storage Management

A Tablespace is like a drawer in a filing cabinet. The whole cabinet is the database, and each drawer holds different types of files. Every table, index, or object in Oracle lives inside a tablespace.

2.1 Tablespace Interview Q&A

Q: What is a Tablespace and what are the different types?

A: A Tablespace is a logical storage unit that holds database objects like tables and indexes. Types: 1) SYSTEM Tablespace — Created automatically. Holds the data dictionary (Oracle's internal tables about the database). Never store user data here. 2) SYSAUX Tablespace — Helper to SYSTEM. Holds data for Oracle tools like AWR. 3) TEMP Tablespace — Holds temporary data for sorting and joins. Not permanent storage. 4) UNDO Tablespace — Stores old/previous versions of data before changes were committed. Used for rollbacks and flashback. 5) USER / Application Tablespace — Where you store actual application tables and data.

⭐ **IMPORTANT: What is SYSTEM tablespace and why can't we store user data there?**

Q: What is SYSTEM tablespace and why can't we store user data there?

A: SYSTEM tablespace is created when the database is first created. It holds all data dictionary tables — these are Oracle's internal tables that track all objects, users, permissions, and configurations in the database. If SYSTEM tablespace gets full or corrupted, the entire database stops working. That is why we NEVER store user data in SYSTEM. If it fills up, even Oracle's own operations fail. Best practice: Always create a separate tablespace for application data.

Q: What is an UNDO tablespace? Why is it important?

A: UNDO tablespace stores the OLD version of data before changes are made. Example: Imagine you are editing a Word document. UNDO is like the 'ctrl+Z' history. When a user does UPDATE or DELETE without COMMIT, Oracle saves the old data in UNDO. Uses of UNDO: 1) ROLLBACK — If a transaction is rolled back, Oracle restores old data from UNDO. 2) Read Consistency — Other users can still see the old data while you are making changes. 3) Flashback — You can go back in time to see what data looked like before.

Q: What is the difference between a PERMANENT and TEMPORARY tablespace?

A: PERMANENT tablespace stores permanent objects like tables, indexes, and stored procedures. This data persists even after the database restarts. TEMPORARY tablespace stores data only during a session — for example, when Oracle needs extra space to sort a large query or do a JOIN between huge tables. Once the query finishes, temporary tablespace data is gone. Every user must have a default temp tablespace assigned.

Q: Scenario: A user calls saying their query is very slow and the temp tablespace is 100% full. What do you do?

A: Step 1: Confirm the issue — Check temp tablespace usage: SELECT tablespace_name, used_blocks, free_blocks FROM v$sort_segment. Step 2: Find the session using temp space: SELECT sql_id, username, sql_text FROM v$sql WHERE ... Step 3: Short-term fix — Add a temp file to temp tablespace: ALTER TABLESPACE temp ADD TEMPFILE '/path/file.dbf' SIZE 2G. Step 4: Long-term fix — Investigate why the query uses so much temp space. It may need an index or query rewrite. Step 5: Kill long-running sessions if they are holding temp space unnecessarily.

Q: How do you check tablespace usage in Oracle?

A: Use this SQL query: SELECT df.tablespace_name, ROUND(df.total_mb,2) total_mb, ROUND(df.total_mb - fs.free_mb,2) used_mb, ROUND(fs.free_mb,2) free_mb, ROUND((df.total_mb-fs.free_mb)/df.total_mb*100,2) pct_used FROM (SELECT tablespace_name, SUM(bytes)/1048576 total_mb FROM dba_data_files GROUP BY tablespace_name) df, (SELECT tablespace_name, SUM(bytes)/1048576 free_mb FROM dba_free_space GROUP BY tablespace_name) fs WHERE df.tablespace_name = fs.tablespace_name ORDER BY pct_used DESC.

💡 *Always check DBA_TABLESPACES, DBA_DATA_FILES, and DBA_FREE_SPACE views for tablespace info. These 3 views come up in almost every interview.*

- ✔ 5 tablespace types: SYSTEM, SYSAUX, TEMP, UNDO, User/App tablespace
- ✔ Never store user data in SYSTEM tablespace
- ✔ UNDO = 'Ctrl+Z' for transactions. TEMP = scratch paper for queries
- ✔ To add space: ALTER TABLESPACE ... ADD DATAFILE
- ✔ Key views: DBA_TABLESPACES, DBA_DATA_FILES, DBA_FREE_SPACE, V$SORT_SEGMENT

SECTION 3: User Management & Security

Managing users is one of the most common daily tasks for a DBA. Think of it like being the HR manager of a company — you create employee accounts, decide who can access which rooms, and remove access when someone leaves.

3.1 User & Privilege Q&A

Q: How do you create a user in Oracle?

A: CREATE USER john IDENTIFIED BY password123 DEFAULT TABLESPACE users TEMPORARY TABLESPACE temp QUOTA 100M ON users; Then grant minimum privileges: GRANT CREATE SESSION TO john; (This allows the user to log in.) For a developer: GRANT CREATE TABLE, CREATE VIEW, CREATE PROCEDURE TO john;

Q: What is the difference between a PRIVILEGE and a ROLE in Oracle?

A: A PRIVILEGE is a single specific permission, like 'CREATE TABLE' or 'SELECT on HR.EMPLOYEES'. A ROLE is a named collection of privileges grouped together. Example: The role DBA contains hundreds of privileges. Instead of granting 50 privileges one by one, you just say GRANT DBA TO john. Common built-in roles: CONNECT (basic login), RESOURCE (create objects), DBA (full control). Best practice: Grant roles, not individual privileges, for easier management.

Q: What is the difference between OBJECT privilege and SYSTEM privilege?

A: SYSTEM privilege gives the right to do database-wide operations: CREATE USER, CREATE TABLE, DROP ANY TABLE. OBJECT privilege gives rights on a specific object owned by someone: GRANT SELECT ON hr.employees TO john — this lets John read only that one table. Another example: GRANT UPDATE ON hr.salary TO finance_team.

⭐ **IMPORTANT: What is the difference between GRANT and REVOKE? Can revoke cascade?**

Q: What is the difference between GRANT and REVOKE? What happens with REVOKE CASCADE?

A: GRANT gives permission: GRANT SELECT ON employees TO john. REVOKE takes permission back: REVOKE SELECT ON employees FROM john. CASCADE in REVOKE: If John gave SELECT to Mary (using WITH GRANT OPTION), and you revoke from John, Mary also loses access automatically. This is called Cascade Revoke. Tip: Use WITH GRANT OPTION carefully — it can create a chain of permissions that are hard to track.

Q: A user is locked out of their account. How do you unlock it?

A: Step 1: Find out the account status: SELECT username, account_status, lock_date FROM dba_users WHERE username = 'JOHN'. Step 2: Unlock the account: ALTER USER john ACCOUNT UNLOCK. Step 3: If password also expired: ALTER USER john IDENTIFIED BY newpassword123. Step 4: Check if the account is locked due to too many failed login attempts — this is controlled by a PROFILE. Check: SELECT profile FROM dba_users WHERE username = 'JOHN'.

Q: What is an Oracle Profile and why do we use it?

A: A Profile is a set of resource limits and password rules applied to a user. Like a company policy document for database access. Profile settings include: 1) FAILED_LOGIN_ATTEMPTS — How many wrong passwords before lockout (e.g., 5 attempts). 2) PASSWORD_LIFE_TIME — How many days before password expires. 3) PASSWORD_REUSE_TIME — How many days before old password can be reused. 4) CPU_PER_SESSION — Max CPU a session can use. Create profile: CREATE PROFILE app_user LIMIT FAILED_LOGIN_ATTEMPTS 5 PASSWORD_LIFE_TIME 90. Assign: ALTER USER john PROFILE app_user.

💡 *Interview tip: When asked about security, always mention Profiles, Password Policies, and Least Privilege Principle (give only what is needed, nothing more).*

✔ CREATE USER ... IDENTIFIED BY ... DEFAULT TABLESPACE ... TEMP TABLESPACE ...
✔ Always GRANT CREATE SESSION for a user to log in
✔ Role = bundle of privileges (CONNECT, RESOURCE, DBA)
✔ Profile = rules for password and resource limits per user
✔ Key views: DBA_USERS, DBA_ROLES, DBA_SYS_PRIVS, DBA_TAB_PRIVS, DBA_ROLE_PRIVS

SECTION 4: Backup & Recovery

Backup and Recovery is THE most important topic in any DBA interview. If data is lost, the DBA is responsible for getting it back. Think of backup as buying insurance for your house — you hope you never need it, but when disaster strikes, you are glad you had it.

⭐ **IMPORTANT: Backup & Recovery questions appear in 90% of DBA interviews. Know this section very well.**

4.1 Backup Types — Q&A

Q: What are the different types of backups in Oracle?

A: Two main categories: 1) PHYSICAL BACKUP: Copies actual database files (data files, control files, redo logs). Done using RMAN or OS commands. Sub-types: a) Hot Backup (Online Backup) — taken while database is running. b) Cold Backup (Offline Backup) — taken while database is shut down. 2) LOGICAL BACKUP: Exports database objects (tables, schemas) using Data Pump (expdp/impdp) or old exp/imp tools. Does NOT include redo logs. Good for migrating data or creating test copies.

Q: What is the difference between Hot Backup and Cold Backup?

A: HOT BACKUP (Online): Database is running while backup is taken. Users can still work. Requires ARCHIVELOG mode. Used for 24/7 systems like banking websites. COLD BACKUP (Offline): Database must be SHUT DOWN completely before backup. Very simple — just copy the files. Downside: Downtime required. Used for systems that can afford maintenance windows (e.g., Sunday night at 2 AM). Interview tip: Most production databases use Hot Backup because they cannot afford downtime.

Q: What is the difference between Full Backup, Incremental Backup, and Differential Backup?

A: FULL BACKUP: Everything is backed up. Takes the most time and space. INCREMENTAL BACKUP: Only data changed since the last backup (full OR incremental) is backed up. Example: Full backup Sunday. Monday incremental backs up only Monday's changes. Tuesday incremental backs up only Tuesday's changes. DIFFERENTIAL BACKUP: Data changed since the last FULL backup is backed up. Example: Full backup Sunday. Monday differential = all changes since Sunday. Tuesday differential = all changes since Sunday again (so it grows each day). Recovery is faster with differential. Storage grows faster with differential.

🧠 **Memory Trick: Full = Everything. Incremental = Since last ANY backup. Differential = Since last FULL backup. FID: 'Full Is Different'**

Q: What is ARCHIVELOG mode and why is it important?

A: Oracle redo logs are written in a circular fashion — when one log fills up, Oracle starts writing to the next one and eventually overwrites old logs. ARCHIVELOG mode means: Before Oracle overwrites an old redo log, it first copies (archives) it to another location. This gives you a complete history of all changes ever made. WITHOUT archivelog: You can only restore to the last backup time. WITH archivelog: You can restore to ANY point in time, even 1 second before a crash. Check: SELECT log_mode FROM v$database. Enable: SHUTDOWN IMMEDIATE; STARTUP MOUNT; ALTER DATABASE ARCHIVELOG; ALTER DATABASE OPEN;

Q: What is the difference between RESTORE and RECOVER?

A: RESTORE = Copying backup files back to their original location (from tape, disk, cloud). Like moving a backup copy of your files back to your computer. RECOVER = Applying redo logs (archived logs) to the restored files to bring them up to date. Example: Full backup Friday 11 PM. Crash Saturday 9 AM. RESTORE: Copy Friday 11 PM backup back to disk. RECOVER: Apply all archived logs from Friday 11 PM to Saturday 9 AM. Result: Database is back to exact state as Saturday 9 AM.

Q: What is Point-in-Time Recovery (PITR)?

A: PITR means recovering the database to a specific moment in the past — not just the last backup. Example: Developer accidentally ran DELETE FROM ORDERS WHERE 1=1; at 2:15 PM and committed. You want to restore the data to 2:14 PM. With ARCHIVELOG mode, you can do exactly that. RMAN command: RUN { SET UNTIL TIME "TO_DATE('2026-04-10 14:14:00','YYYY-MM-DD HH24:MI:SS')"; RESTORE DATABASE; RECOVER DATABASE; } This is one of the most powerful features a DBA uses.

Q: Scenario: A table was accidentally dropped in production. How do you recover it?

A: Option 1 — Flashback Table (if Recycle Bin is enabled): FLASHBACK TABLE employees TO BEFORE DROP; Quick, no downtime, no need for backups. Option 2 — Flashback Query (if data changed but not dropped): SELECT * FROM employees AS OF TIMESTAMP (SYSTIMESTAMP - INTERVAL '30' MINUTE); Option 3 — RMAN Point-in-Time Recovery: Restore a test database to the time before the drop, export the table, import into production. Option 4 — Tablespace Point-in-Time Recovery (TSPITR): More advanced recovery for a specific tablespace.

💡 *In scenario-based questions, always mention multiple options and explain why you would choose one over another based on the situation (how much time has passed, whether archivelog is enabled, etc.).*

✔ Hot Backup = database running. Cold Backup = database shut down

✔ ARCHIVELOG mode is required for Hot Backup and Point-in-Time Recovery

✔ RESTORE = copy files back. RECOVER = apply redo logs to make current

✔ Flashback Table = fast recovery of dropped/changed tables
✔ Key views: V$DATABASE, V$ARCHIVED_LOG, V$BACKUP, V$RECOVER_FILE

SECTION 5: RMAN — Recovery Manager

RMAN (Recovery Manager) is Oracle's built-in tool for backup and recovery. Think of RMAN as a professional moving company — instead of moving all your furniture yourself (manual backup), RMAN does it efficiently, keeps records, and can detect damaged items (corrupt blocks).

5.1 RMAN Core Q&A

Q: What is RMAN and why is it better than manual (user-managed) backup?

A: RMAN is Oracle's built-in backup and recovery tool that automates the entire process. Advantages over manual backup: 1) Automatic tracking — RMAN records every backup in a catalog (repository). You always know what was backed up, when, and where. 2) Incremental backup support — Only backs up changed blocks, saving time and space. 3) Block-level corruption detection — RMAN detects and reports corrupt data blocks during backup. 4) Compression — Can compress backups to save storage space. 5) Scripting — Backup scripts can be saved and scheduled to run automatically. 6) Restore testing — You can test if a backup is recoverable without actually restoring.

Q: What is the RMAN Recovery Catalog and do you need it?

A: The Recovery Catalog is a separate Oracle database schema that stores RMAN's backup metadata (what was backed up, when, location, scripts). Without catalog: RMAN stores metadata in the target database's CONTROL FILE. This works fine for single databases but has limitations. With catalog: You can manage backups for many databases from one place. Better history retention. Can store reusable RMAN scripts. In most production environments, a catalog is recommended. Create: Create a separate database, create a catalog user, run RMAN> CREATE CATALOG.

Q: What is the RMAN Fast Recovery Area (FRA)?

A: FRA (Fast Recovery Area) is a dedicated disk location where Oracle automatically stores and manages backup files, archived logs, flashback logs, and control file backups. Benefits: Oracle manages space automatically. Old backups are deleted automatically when space runs low. Simplifies backup administration — one location for all recovery files. Set FRA: ALTER SYSTEM SET db_recovery_file_dest = '/u01/fra' SCOPE=BOTH; ALTER SYSTEM SET db_recovery_file_dest_size = 100G SCOPE=BOTH; Check: SELECT * FROM v$recovery_file_dest;

⭐ **IMPORTANT: Common RMAN commands — must know for interview**

Q: What are the most important RMAN commands you use daily?

A: Connect to RMAN: rman target / (on same server) or rman target sys@PROD. Common commands: 1) BACKUP DATABASE PLUS ARCHIVELOG; — Full backup including archive logs. 2) BACKUP INCREMENTAL LEVEL 0 DATABASE; — Level 0 baseline (like a full

backup for incrementals). 3) BACKUP INCREMENTAL LEVEL 1 DATABASE; — Level 1: backs up changes since last Level 0 or Level 1. 4) LIST BACKUP; — Shows all backups. 5) REPORT OBSOLETE; — Shows old backups that can be deleted. 6) DELETE OBSOLETE; — Removes old backups. 7) CROSSCHECK BACKUP; — Verifies backup files still exist. 8) RESTORE DATABASE; — Restores backup files. 9) RECOVER DATABASE; — Applies redo logs after restore.

Q: What is the difference between RMAN Level 0 and Level 1 incremental backup?

A: Think of it like building a house. Level 0 = Foundation (full backup, but formatted for incremental use). Level 1 = Additional floors built on top of the foundation (only the changes since Level 0). Level 0 backup on Sunday: Backs up ALL blocks. Level 1 backup on Monday: Backs up only blocks changed since Sunday. Level 1 backup on Tuesday: Backs up only blocks changed since Monday (DIFFERENTIAL) OR since the last Level 0 (CUMULATIVE). DIFFERENTIAL Level 1 = smaller backups, longer recovery. CUMULATIVE Level 1 = bigger backups, faster recovery.

Q: Scenario: RMAN backup is failing with 'ORA-19809: limit exceeded for recovery files'. What do you do?

A: This error means the Fast Recovery Area (FRA) is full. Steps: 1) Check FRA usage: SELECT * FROM v$recovery_file_dest; 2) Delete obsolete backups: RMAN> DELETE OBSOLETE; 3) If still full, delete expired backups: RMAN> CROSSCHECK BACKUP; RMAN> DELETE EXPIRED BACKUP; 4) Increase FRA size if needed: ALTER SYSTEM SET db_recovery_file_dest_size = 200G SCOPE=BOTH; 5) Move old archive logs to tape or external storage. 6) Long-term: Review backup retention policy.

Q: What are expired and obsolete backups in RMAN?

A: OBSOLETE backup: A backup that is no longer needed according to your retention policy. Example: If you keep 7 days of backups and today is Day 8, Day 1's backup becomes obsolete. EXPIRED backup: A backup that RMAN thinks exists but the actual file is missing from disk. Maybe someone deleted it manually. CROSSCHECK identifies expired backups. DELETE OBSOLETE removes obsolete ones. DELETE EXPIRED removes records of expired (missing) ones from the repository.

🧠 **Memory Trick: OBSOLETE = old but file exists. EXPIRED = file is gone/missing. 'Milk expires, old news is obsolete.'**

- ✔ RMAN connects as: rman target /
- ✔ BACKUP DATABASE PLUS ARCHIVELOG = most common full backup command
- ✔ FRA = Fast Recovery Area — Oracle manages backup storage automatically
- ✔ Level 0 = baseline, Level 1 = changes only

✔ CROSSCHECK = verify files exist. DELETE OBSOLETE = clean old backups
✔ Key views: V$RMAN_BACKUP_JOB_DETAILS, V$RECOVERY_FILE_DEST, V$ARCHIVED_LOG

SECTION 6: Indexing

An Index in a database is exactly like the index at the back of a book. Instead of reading every page to find a topic, you look at the index and jump straight to the right page. Without indexes, Oracle reads every row of a table (called Full Table Scan) which is very slow for large tables.

6.1 Index Interview Q&A

Q: What is an Index and when should you create one?

A: An Index is a database object that helps Oracle find data faster, similar to a book's index. Create an index when: 1) A column is frequently used in WHERE clauses. 2) A column is used in JOINs between tables. 3) A table has millions of rows and queries are slow. Do NOT create an index when: 1) The table is very small (full scan is faster). 2) The column has very few unique values (like a Yes/No column — called low cardinality). 3) The table has many INSERT/UPDATE/DELETE operations (indexes slow down writes).

Q: What is the difference between a B-Tree index and a Bitmap index?

A: B-TREE INDEX: Default index type. Works like a tree structure where Oracle starts from the root and traverses down to find the exact row. Best for HIGH CARDINALITY columns (columns with many unique values) like Employee ID, Email, Phone Number. BITMAP INDEX: Stores a bitmap (0s and 1s) for each unique value. Best for LOW CARDINALITY columns (few unique values) like Gender (M/F), Status (Active/Inactive), Department (only 5 departments). BITMAP is great for data warehouses with lots of reads but terrible for tables with frequent updates (because updating one row can lock many rows due to the bitmap).

Q: What is a Clustered Index vs Non-Clustered Index?

A: CLUSTERED INDEX: The table rows are physically sorted on disk in the same order as the index. Like a phone book sorted by last name — the data itself is sorted. A table can have only ONE clustered index. NONCLUSTERED INDEX: A separate structure that points to the actual data rows. Like a book's index at the back — it points you to the page, but the book itself is not sorted by that index. A table can have many nonclustered indexes.

Q: What is an invisible index and when would you use it?

A: An INVISIBLE index exists in the database but the Oracle optimizer IGNORES it when generating query plans — unless you specifically hint the query to use it. Use case: You want to test if a new index will help performance WITHOUT affecting production queries. Create: CREATE INDEX idx_emp_name ON employees(last_name) INVISIBLE; Test: SELECT /*+ INDEX(e idx_emp_name) */ * FROM employees e WHERE last_name = 'Smith'; If testing shows improvement, make it visible: ALTER INDEX idx_emp_name VISIBLE; If not, just drop it with no impact.

Q: Scenario: A query that was fast last month is now running very slowly. The table has an index. What could be the problem?

A: Possible causes and solutions: 1) Statistics are outdated — Oracle's optimizer uses statistics to decide how to run a query. If statistics are old, Oracle may choose a wrong/slow plan. Fix: EXEC DBMS_STATS.GATHER_TABLE_STATS('SCHEMA', 'TABLE_NAME'); 2) Index has become fragmented — After many INSERT/DELETE operations, index becomes unbalanced. Fix: ALTER INDEX idx_emp ON employees REBUILD; 3) Index became unusable — After partition truncation or failed operations. Fix: ALTER INDEX idx_emp REBUILD; 4) Query plan changed — Check execution plan: EXPLAIN PLAN FOR SELECT ... ; SELECT * FROM TABLE(DBMS_XPLAN.DISPLAY);

💡 *Always check execution plan when a query is slow. Command: EXPLAIN PLAN FOR <query>; then SELECT * FROM TABLE(DBMS_XPLAN.DISPLAY);*

✔ Index = book index. Helps Oracle find rows without reading whole table
✔ B-Tree = high cardinality (many unique values). Bitmap = low cardinality
✔ One clustered index per table. Many nonclustered indexes possible
✔ Invisible index = test without affecting queries
✔ Slow query? Check: statistics, index fragmentation, execution plan

SECTION 7: Performance Tuning

Performance tuning means making the database faster and more efficient. As a mid-level DBA, interviewers expect you to know how to identify performance problems and fix them using Oracle's built-in tools.

⭐ **IMPORTANT: Performance tuning is a heavily tested area. Focus on AWR, ADDM, and wait events.**

7.1 Performance Tuning Q&A

Q: What tools does Oracle provide for performance monitoring?

A: 1) AWR (Automatic Workload Repository) — Takes snapshots of database performance every hour automatically. You can generate an AWR report to see exactly what was happening during a slow period. 2) ADDM (Automatic Database Diagnostic Monitor) — Analyzes AWR snapshots and automatically tells you what the TOP problems are and how to fix them. Like having an expert DBA analyze your database automatically. 3) ASH (Active Session History) — Captures what every active session was doing every second. Useful for diagnosing short performance spikes. 4) OEM (Oracle Enterprise Manager) — Graphical web interface that shows all performance data visually. 5) TKPROF / SQL Trace — For detailed analysis of specific SQL queries.

Q: What is an AWR Report and how do you generate it?

A: AWR (Automatic Workload Repository) automatically takes a 'snapshot' of database performance every 60 minutes by default and stores it for 8 days. An AWR report shows: Top 5 timed events (where Oracle spent most time), Top SQL queries by CPU/elapsed time, Buffer cache hit ratio, and Memory usage. Generate AWR report: @$ORACLE_HOME/rdbms/admin/awrrpt.sql. Then choose HTML or text format, select the snapshot range (e.g., from 8 AM to 9 AM when it was slow), and the report is generated. Interview tip: Say you review AWR reports proactively every morning to catch issues before users report them.

Q: What are Wait Events in Oracle? Name some common ones.

A: When an Oracle process cannot do its work immediately and has to wait for something, it records a 'wait event'. Top wait events tell you WHERE your database is spending time waiting. Common wait events: 1) 'db file sequential read' — Reading single rows by index. Normal, but if too high, add better indexes. 2) 'db file scattered read' — Full table scan. May mean missing indexes. 3) 'log file sync' — Waiting for redo logs to be written (LGWR). Can mean disk I/O bottleneck. 4) 'buffer busy waits' — Multiple sessions competing for same data block. Investigate hot blocks. 5) 'enq: TX - row lock contention' — A row is locked by one session; another is waiting. Application-level lock issue.

Q: What is a blocking session? How do you find and fix it?

A: A blocking session is one user's transaction that holds a lock on a row/table, preventing another user from modifying that data. Example: User A updates Employee #5 but doesn't COMMIT. User B tries to update Employee #5 and gets stuck — this is a blocking session. How to find: SELECT blocking_session, sid, wait_class, seconds_in_wait FROM v$session WHERE blocking_session IS NOT NULL. Fix options: 1) Ask the blocking session user to commit or rollback. 2) Kill the blocking session: ALTER SYSTEM KILL SESSION 'sid,serial#'. 3) Long-term: Application should have proper COMMIT after every transaction.

Q: What is the difference between a Hard Parse and Soft Parse?

A: When Oracle runs a SQL query for the first time, it does a HARD PARSE: validates syntax, checks permissions, creates an execution plan, and stores it in the Shared Pool (memory). Next time the SAME query runs, Oracle does a SOFT PARSE: finds the existing plan in Shared Pool and reuses it. Hard Parse is expensive (uses CPU and memory). Soft Parse is cheap and fast. Problem: If developers write queries with hardcoded values (SELECT * FROM emp WHERE id = 1001), each different value causes a hard parse. Solution: Use BIND VARIABLES (SELECT * FROM emp WHERE id = :id_var) so the same plan is reused for all values.

Q: Scenario: The database is suddenly very slow. What are your first 5 steps?

A: Step 1: Check if the database is even up: SELECT status FROM v$instance. Step 2: Check for active blocking sessions: SELECT sid, blocking_session, wait_class FROM v$session WHERE blocking_session IS NOT NULL. Step 3: Check top wait events right now: SELECT event, count(*) FROM v$session WHERE wait_class != 'Idle' GROUP BY event ORDER BY 2 DESC. Step 4: Check if there are runaway queries (long-running SQL): SELECT sql_id, elapsed_time, executions, sql_text FROM v$sql ORDER BY elapsed_time DESC FETCH FIRST 10 ROWS ONLY. Step 5: Check alert log for errors: SELECT originating_timestamp, message_text FROM v$diag_alert_ext WHERE message_text LIKE '%ORA-%' ORDER BY 1 DESC FETCH FIRST 20 ROWS ONLY.

🧠 **Memory Trick: For 'database is slow' questions: Always answer in order — Sessions > Locks > Wait Events > SQL > Alert Log. Like a doctor doing vitals first before complex tests.**

✔ AWR = hourly snapshots. ADDM = automatic diagnosis. ASH = per-second session history
✔ Wait events = where Oracle is spending time waiting
✔ Blocking sessions = one user locking rows, others waiting
✔ Hard Parse = expensive, first-time SQL execution. Use bind variables to avoid
✔ Key views: V$SESSION, V$SQL, V$ACTIVE_SESSION_HISTORY, V$EVENT_NAME

SECTION 8: Data Guard (High Availability)

Data Guard is Oracle's disaster recovery solution. Imagine you run a bank's database in Mumbai. If the Mumbai data center burns down, you need a copy of the database running in Delhi that can take over immediately. That is exactly what Data Guard does.

8.1 Data Guard Q&A

Q: What is Oracle Data Guard and what problem does it solve?

A: Data Guard maintains one or more STANDBY databases that are exact copies of the PRIMARY database. Changes from the primary are automatically sent to the standby and applied there. Solves: 1) Disaster Recovery — If primary fails, standby takes over (Failover). 2) Planned maintenance — Switch to standby, patch primary, switch back (Switchover). 3) Reduces backup load — Take backups from standby instead of primary. 4) Reporting — Run read-only queries on standby (Active Data Guard) instead of loading primary.

Q: What is the difference between a Physical Standby and a Logical Standby?

A: PHYSICAL STANDBY: An exact byte-for-byte copy of the primary database. Redo logs from primary are applied to standby using REDO APPLY. In standby mode: Read-only (or completely closed). Best for: Disaster recovery, most common type. LOGICAL STANDBY: SQL changes are extracted from redo logs and re-executed as SQL on the standby. Standby can be open for read-write queries on non-replicated objects. Best for: Reporting on specific tables while replication runs. Harder to set up and maintain.

Q: What is Switchover vs Failover in Data Guard?

A: SWITCHOVER: Planned role change. Primary becomes standby, standby becomes primary. No data loss. Used for: Maintenance, upgrades, testing DR readiness. Steps: DGMGRL> SWITCHOVER TO standby_db. FAILOVER: Emergency role change when primary is down and NOT coming back. May have some data loss (depends on protection mode). Used for: Actual disaster — primary database/server is destroyed. Steps: DGMGRL> FAILOVER TO standby_db. After failover, old primary must be rebuilt as a new standby.

Q: What are Data Guard Protection Modes?

A: 1) MAXIMUM AVAILABILITY (default recommended): No data loss if primary fails. Redo logs are written to standby synchronously, but if standby is unavailable, primary continues. 2) MAXIMUM PERFORMANCE: Best performance. Redo is sent asynchronously — primary does not wait for standby confirmation. Small risk of data loss on failover. 3) MAXIMUM PROTECTION: Absolutely no data loss guaranteed. Primary STOPS if it cannot write redo to standby. Risk: If standby is slow/down, primary halts. Used only when data loss is absolutely unacceptable (e.g., financial systems).

Q: What is Active Data Guard?

A: Standard Data Guard: Standby is closed or read-only. Active Data Guard (ADG): Standby database is OPEN FOR READ while redo apply is running simultaneously. Users can run reports and queries on the standby — reducing load on primary. Requires an additional license (not free). Great for: Read-heavy applications, reporting, analytics.

💡 *In interviews, when asked about high availability, mention both Data Guard (for DR) and RAC (for local HA). They solve different problems and complement each other.*

✔ Data Guard = Primary + Standby database(s). Changes flow from Primary to Standby
✔ Physical Standby = exact copy. Logical Standby = SQL-based copy
✔ Switchover = planned (no data loss). Failover = emergency (possible data loss)
✔ 3 protection modes: Maximum Availability, Maximum Performance, Maximum Protection
✔ Active Data Guard = standby open for reads while receiving changes

SECTION 9: RAC — Real Application Clusters

RAC is Oracle's solution for having multiple servers all running the same database at the same time. Imagine a bank with 2 ATMs connected to the same account — both can read and update your balance simultaneously. RAC does this for databases.

9.1 RAC Q&A

Q: What is Oracle RAC and what problems does it solve?

A: RAC (Real Application Clusters) allows multiple servers (called NODES) to connect to a SINGLE shared database simultaneously. Each node runs its own Oracle instance, but all instances share the same database files on shared storage. Problems it solves: 1) Single Point of Failure — If one node crashes, other nodes continue serving users. No downtime. 2) Scalability — Need more capacity? Add another node. 3) High Availability — Users are automatically redirected to working nodes. Data Guard protects from site failures; RAC protects from node/server failures.

Q: What is Cache Fusion in RAC and why is it important?

A: In RAC, each node has its own Buffer Cache (memory). When Node 1 needs a data block that Node 2 has already modified and is holding in its cache, Oracle transfers that block DIRECTLY from Node 2's memory to Node 1's memory via the private interconnect network. This direct memory-to-memory transfer is called Cache Fusion. Without Cache Fusion, Node 1 would have to write the block to disk, then read it back — much slower. Cache Fusion makes RAC perform well despite multiple instances sharing data.

Q: What is the difference between Data Guard and RAC?

A: RAC: Multiple servers running the SAME database at the same location (same data center). Protects against: Server failure (node crash). Does NOT protect against: Site/data center failure or data corruption. DATA GUARD: Multiple databases at DIFFERENT locations (primary + standby). Protects against: Site failure, data center disaster, data corruption. Does NOT help with: Load balancing or scalability on a single site. Best practice: Use BOTH — RAC for local HA and scalability, Data Guard for disaster recovery.

Q: What is ASM (Automatic Storage Management) and how does RAC use it?

A: ASM is Oracle's built-in volume manager and file system for Oracle database files. Instead of using OS-level file systems, Oracle manages disk storage directly. Why RAC needs ASM: In RAC, all nodes need to access the SAME data files simultaneously. ASM provides a shared file system that all nodes can access at the same time. ASM also automatically balances data across available disks and can use disk groups with mirroring for redundancy.

🧠 **Memory Trick: RAC = Multiple servers, ONE database. DG = ONE server (primary), COPY database elsewhere. RAC = Scalability & Local HA. DG = Disaster Recovery.**

✔ RAC = Multiple nodes, shared storage, one database
✔ Cache Fusion = data blocks transferred directly between node memory via interconnect
✔ RAC protects against node failure. Data Guard protects against site failure
✔ ASM provides shared storage accessible to all RAC nodes
✔ VIP (Virtual IP) and SCAN (Single Client Access Name) handle client connections in RAC

SECTION 10: SQL Server DBA Basics

SQL Server is Microsoft's database product, similar to Oracle but with different terminology and tools. Many companies use BOTH Oracle and SQL Server, so knowing the differences and similarities is important.

10.1 SQL Server Core Q&A

Q: What is SQL Server and how is it different from Oracle?

A: SQL Server (Microsoft SQL Server) is a relational database management system (RDBMS) made by Microsoft. Main differences from Oracle: 1) Oracle uses SCHEMAS; SQL Server uses DATABASES + SCHEMAS. 2) Oracle's backup tool is RMAN; SQL Server uses SQL Server Backup or third-party tools. 3) Oracle's HA is Data Guard + RAC; SQL Server uses AlwaysOn Availability Groups + Failover Clustering. 4) Oracle runs on Linux and Windows; SQL Server also runs on both (since 2017). 5) Oracle uses PL/SQL for stored procedures; SQL Server uses T-SQL (Transact-SQL). 6) Oracle DBA uses SQL*Plus; SQL Server DBA uses SSMS (SQL Server Management Studio).

Q: What is ACID in databases? Explain with a simple example.

A: ACID stands for Atomicity, Consistency, Isolation, Durability. These are rules that ensure database transactions are safe. Example: Bank transfer of Rs. 1000 from Account A to Account B. ATOMICITY: Either both happen (debit A AND credit B) OR neither happens. No partial transfer. CONSISTENCY: Before = A has Rs. 5000, B has Rs. 3000 (total Rs. 8000). After = A has Rs. 4000, B has Rs. 4000 (total still Rs. 8000). Balance preserved. ISOLATION: While transfer is in progress, another user cannot see the intermediate state. DURABILITY: Once transfer is COMMITTED, even if server crashes immediately after, the change is permanent.

Q: What are Isolation Levels in SQL Server and Oracle?

A: Isolation levels control how much one transaction can 'see' the changes made by other concurrent transactions. From least to most strict: 1) READ UNCOMMITTED — Can read data even if it is not committed (dirty read). Fastest but risky. 2) READ COMMITTED — Can only read committed data. Default in SQL Server and Oracle. 3) REPEATABLE READ — Same row read twice in a transaction gives same result. 4) SERIALIZABLE — Highest isolation. Transactions run as if one at a time. Slowest. SQL Server also has SNAPSHOT isolation — uses version store to give readers a consistent view without blocking writers.

Q: What are the different types of SQL Server backups?

A: 1) FULL BACKUP: Backs up entire database. Starting point for any restore. 2) DIFFERENTIAL BACKUP: Backs up all changes since the last FULL backup. Restore requires: Last FULL + latest DIFFERENTIAL. 3) TRANSACTION LOG BACKUP: Backs up the transaction log. Allows point-in-time recovery. Requires FULL RECOVERY model. 4)

COPY-ONLY BACKUP: A special full backup that does not break the backup chain. Used when you need a one-off backup for testing without affecting your regular schedule. Recovery models: SIMPLE = no log backups. FULL = full log backups, point-in-time recovery. BULK LOGGED = like FULL but minimally logs bulk operations.

Q: What is SQL Server AlwaysOn Availability Groups?

A: AlwaysOn AG is SQL Server's high availability and disaster recovery solution — similar to Oracle Data Guard. It maintains secondary replica databases that receive changes from the primary. Features: 1) Up to 8 secondaries (2 synchronous, 6 asynchronous). 2) Secondaries can be used for READ operations (like Active Data Guard). 3) Automatic Failover when using synchronous replicas with a Windows Failover Cluster. 4) Manual Failover for planned maintenance. Uses an Availability Group Listener (like an Oracle SCAN listener) as a single connection point that automatically redirects clients to the current primary.

Q: What is a SQL Server Agent Job and why do DBAs use it?

A: SQL Server Agent is the built-in scheduler in SQL Server — like Oracle's DBMS_SCHEDULER. DBAs use Agent Jobs to automate: 1) Backup jobs (run backups at midnight). 2) Statistics update jobs. 3) Index maintenance (rebuild/reorganize indexes weekly). 4) Database health check scripts. 5) Alert notifications (email when disk is 90% full). Tip: Interview often asks 'how do you maintain a database proactively?' — mention Agent Jobs for automation.

Q: What is a CTE (Common Table Expression) in SQL?

A: A CTE is a temporary, named result set that you define at the start of a query using the WITH keyword. It exists only for that one query. Why use it: 1) Makes complex queries easier to read by breaking them into steps. 2) Can reference the same result set multiple times. 3) Recursive CTEs can query hierarchical data (like org charts). Example: WITH recent_orders AS (SELECT order_id, user_id, ROW_NUMBER() OVER (PARTITION BY user_id ORDER BY order_date DESC) AS rn FROM orders) SELECT * FROM recent_orders WHERE rn = 1; This finds the most recent order per user — clean and easy to understand.

Q: What is the difference between a Clustered and Non-Clustered index in SQL Server?

A: CLUSTERED INDEX: The actual table data rows are sorted and stored in the order of the clustered index key. A table can have only ONE clustered index. Usually on the Primary Key. The leaf pages of the index ARE the data pages. NONCLUSTERED INDEX: A separate structure that stores the index key and a pointer (Row ID or clustered key) to the actual data row. A table can have up to 999 nonclustered indexes. Use nonclustered indexes on columns frequently used in WHERE, JOIN, or ORDER BY clauses.

💡 *If asked 'how do you improve a slow SQL query in SQL Server?', answer: 1) Check execution plan in SSMS. 2) Look for table scans — add missing indexes. 3) Update statistics. 4) Use covering indexes. 5) Rewrite query to avoid functions on indexed columns.*

✔ SQL Server: SSMS tool, T-SQL language, Agent for scheduling
✔ ACID: Atomicity, Consistency, Isolation, Durability
✔ SQL Server backup: Full + Differential + Transaction Log
✔ AlwaysOn AG = SQL Server's equivalent of Oracle Data Guard
✔ CTE = temporary named query for cleaner, readable SQL

SECTION 11: Patching & Database Monitoring

Patching means applying Oracle-provided updates to fix bugs, security vulnerabilities, and performance issues. Monitoring means watching the database health proactively so problems are caught before they affect users.

11.1 Patching Q&A

Q: What is OPatch and how do you use it?

A: OPatch is Oracle's command-line tool used to apply patches to Oracle software. It is like Windows Update but for Oracle. Common OPatch commands: 1) ./opatch lsinventory — Lists all patches currently applied to Oracle Home. 2) ./opatch apply — Applies a new patch. 3) ./opatch rollback -id <patch_id> — Removes (rolls back) a patch. Important: Applying an OPatch patch is done on Oracle BINARIES (software), NOT on the actual data files. So patch size (e.g., 500 GB database) does not affect how long the patch takes. OPatch takes 30 minutes whether your database has 1 GB or 500 GB of data.

Q: What is a PSU, RU, and RUR in Oracle patching?

A: PSU (Patch Set Update) — Older naming. Quarterly bundle of bug fixes. RU (Release Update) — New naming since Oracle 12.2. Quarterly patch bundle. Contains bug fixes, security fixes. RUR (Release Update Revision) — Monthly smaller patch on top of an RU. Contains only security fixes and critical bugs. Recommended patching strategy: Apply RU quarterly (4 times/year). Apply RUR monthly if critical security patches are needed. Always test in a non-production environment first.

Q: What is the process to apply an Oracle patch? Give the step-by-step.

A: Step 1: Download patch from Oracle Support (support.oracle.com). Step 2: Review the README file in the patch directory. Step 3: Check patch conflicts: ./opatch prereq CheckConflictAgainstOHWithDetail -ph <patch_dir>. Step 4: Stop all services using Oracle (listener, application). Step 5: Apply patch: cd <patch_dir>; ./opatch apply. Step 6: Start listener and database. Step 7: Run datapatch (for database-level changes): cd $ORACLE_HOME/OPatch; ./datapatch -verbose. Step 8: Verify: ./opatch lsinventory | grep <patch_id>. Step 9: Check for invalid objects: SELECT count(*) FROM dba_invalid_objects; Compile if needed: @?/rdbms/admin/utlrp.sql.

11.2 Monitoring Q&A

Q: How do you monitor an Oracle database on a daily basis?

A: Good DBAs have a daily checklist: 1) Check alert log for errors: SELECT message_text FROM v$diag_alert_ext WHERE originating_timestamp > SYSDATE-1 AND message_text LIKE '%ORA-%'. 2) Check if backups were successful (RMAN or backup tool logs). 3) Check

tablespace space usage — alert if >80% full. 4) Check for unusable/invalid objects: SELECT count(*) FROM dba_invalid_objects. 5) Check for failed jobs: SELECT log_date, job_name, status FROM dba_scheduler_job_run_details WHERE status != 'SUCCEEDED' AND log_date > SYSDATE-1. 6) Check active sessions and blocking sessions.

Q: What is an Oracle Alert Log and where is it located?

A: The Alert Log is a text file that records every important event in the Oracle database: startup/shutdown times, ORA- errors, redo log switches, parameter changes, and more. It is the FIRST place a DBA checks when something goes wrong. Location (Oracle 11g+): $ORACLE_BASE/diag/rdbms/<db_name>/<instance_name>/trace/alert_<instance>.log. In modern Oracle, you can also query it as a view: SELECT * FROM v$diag_alert_ext WHERE message_text LIKE '%ORA-%'. Tip: Set up a monitoring script or OEM alert to email the DBA when new ORA- errors appear.

💡 *Always mention proactive monitoring in interviews. Say: 'I check alert logs daily, review AWR reports, and have automated alerts for disk space and blocking sessions.'*

✔ OPatch: lsinventory (check), apply (install), rollback (remove)
✔ RU = quarterly patch. RUR = monthly security patch
✔ Always run datapatch after OPatch to apply DB-level changes
✔ Alert Log = first place to check for any database problem
✔ Daily monitoring: Alert log, backups, tablespace space, invalid objects

SECTION 12: Important SQL Queries for DBA Interviews

Interviewers often ask you to write SQL queries on the spot. Here are the most commonly tested SQL queries with simple explanations.

12.1 Essential DBA SQL Queries

Q: Write a query to find the top 5 largest tables in the database.

A: SELECT owner, segment_name AS table_name, ROUND(bytes/1024/1024/1024,2) AS size_gb FROM dba_segments WHERE segment_type = 'TABLE' ORDER BY bytes DESC FETCH FIRST 5 ROWS ONLY; --- Explanation: dba_segments shows how much space each database object uses. We filter for type 'TABLE', convert bytes to GB, and get the top 5.

Q: Write a query to find all locked sessions in the database.

A: SELECT s.sid, s.serial#, s.username, s.status, s.blocking_session, l.type, l.mode_held, l.mode_requested FROM v$session s, v$lock l WHERE s.sid = l.sid AND l.block = 1; --- Simpler version: SELECT sid, serial#, username, blocking_session, seconds_in_wait, wait_class FROM v$session WHERE blocking_session IS NOT NULL ORDER BY seconds_in_wait DESC; --- This shows sessions that are waiting because another session has a lock.

Q: Write a query to find all users and their account status.

A: SELECT username, account_status, created, default_tablespace, temporary_tablespace, profile, expiry_date FROM dba_users ORDER BY username; --- Shows all database users with their status (OPEN, LOCKED, EXPIRED), creation date, and assigned tablespace.

Q: Write a query to check if ARCHIVELOG mode is enabled.

A: SELECT name, db_unique_name, log_mode, open_mode FROM v$database; --- Look at LOG_MODE column: ARCHIVELOG = archiving enabled (good for production). NOARCHIVELOG = archiving disabled (only for test/dev or cold backup databases).

Q: Write a query to find invalid objects in the database.

A: SELECT owner, object_name, object_type, status FROM dba_objects WHERE status = 'INVALID' ORDER BY owner, object_type, object_name; --- Invalid objects are procedures, functions, or views that have compilation errors. To fix/compile all: @?/rdbms/admin/utlrp.sql

Q: Write a query to find the most resource-intensive SQL queries right now.

A: SELECT sql_id, ROUND(elapsed_time/1000000,2) elapsed_secs, executions, ROUND(elapsed_time/DECODE(executions,0,1,executions)/1000000,2) avg_secs, SUBSTR(sql_text,1,80) sql_preview FROM v$sql WHERE executions > 0 ORDER BY elapsed_time DESC FETCH FIRST 10 ROWS ONLY; --- This helps you find 'rogue' queries that are consuming too many resources.

Q: Write a query to show free space in all tablespaces.

A: SELECT df.tablespace_name, ROUND(df.total_mb,0) total_mb, ROUND(NVL(fs.free_mb,0),0) free_mb, ROUND((df.total_mb - NVL(fs.free_mb,0))/df.total_mb*100,1) pct_used FROM (SELECT tablespace_name, SUM(bytes)/1048576 total_mb FROM dba_data_files GROUP BY tablespace_name) df LEFT JOIN (SELECT tablespace_name, SUM(bytes)/1048576 free_mb FROM dba_free_space GROUP BY tablespace_name) fs ON df.tablespace_name = fs.tablespace_name ORDER BY pct_used DESC;

Q: How do you find which user is running a specific SQL query?

A: SELECT s.sid, s.serial#, s.username, s.machine, s.program, q.sql_text FROM v$session s JOIN v$sql q ON s.sql_id = q.sql_id WHERE s.status = 'ACTIVE' AND s.username IS NOT NULL ORDER BY s.sid; --- This joins the session view (who is connected) with SQL view (what they are running).

💡 *In SQL-based interviews, always write clean queries. Use aliases, proper indentation. Say 'I would also add a WHERE clause to filter by owner for performance if this were a large database.'*

✔ DBA_SEGMENTS — object sizes. DBA_DATA_FILES — data file info. DBA_FREE_SPACE — free space
✔ V$SESSION — who is connected. V$SQL — what SQL is running
✔ V$DATABASE — database name, mode, status
✔ DBA_OBJECTS — all objects and their status (VALID/INVALID)
✔ UTLRP.SQL — script to recompile all invalid objects

SECTION 13: Troubleshooting Common DBA Scenarios

Scenario-based questions test your practical thinking. Even if you haven't faced the exact scenario, explain a logical, step-by-step approach. Interviewers care more about your thought process than the perfect answer.

⭐ **IMPORTANT: Scenario-based questions are the most common in mid-level DBA interviews. Practice explaining these out loud.**

13.1 Troubleshooting Scenarios

Q: Scenario: ORA-00257 error — 'archiver error, connect internal only, until freed'. What do you do?

A: This means the archive log destination is FULL. Oracle has stopped archiving redo logs, so no new transactions can be committed. Immediate steps: Step 1: Check archive log destination: SHOW PARAMETER log_archive_dest; Step 2: Check disk space: df -h (on Linux). Step 3: Delete old archive logs that are already backed up: RMAN> DELETE ARCHIVELOG ALL COMPLETED BEFORE 'SYSDATE-2'; OR move archive logs to another disk. Step 4: Verify archiving resumes: ALTER SYSTEM ARCHIVE LOG CURRENT; Step 5: Long-term: Configure FRA, monitor archive log space, set up automated deletion policy in RMAN.

Q: Scenario: You receive 'ORA-01653: unable to extend table' error. What do you do?

A: This means a table has run out of space in its tablespace. Steps: Step 1: Find which tablespace is full: SELECT tablespace_name, bytes_used, bytes_free FROM v$temp_space_header; or check dba_free_space. Step 2: Add a data file to the tablespace: ALTER TABLESPACE users ADD DATAFILE '/u01/oradata/users02.dbf' SIZE 2G AUTOEXTEND ON NEXT 256M MAXSIZE 10G; Step 3: Alternatively, turn on AUTOEXTEND for existing data file: ALTER DATABASE DATAFILE '/u01/oradata/users01.dbf' AUTOEXTEND ON NEXT 256M; Step 4: Investigate why table grew so fast — maybe a batch job loaded too much data.

Q: Scenario: Database is not starting. You see 'ORA-00205: error in identifying control file'. What happened and what do you do?

A: The control file is missing, corrupted, or at the wrong location. Control file is critical — without it, the database cannot start. Recovery steps: Option 1 — If you have a multiplexed copy: Find the good copy location. Edit PFILE/SPFILE to point to the good copy. ALTER SYSTEM SET control_files = '/path/to/good/copy' SCOPE=SPFILE; Restart. Option 2 — Restore from RMAN backup: STARTUP NOMOUNT; RESTORE CONTROLFILE FROM AUTOBACKUP; ALTER DATABASE MOUNT; RECOVER DATABASE; ALTER DATABASE OPEN RESETLOGS; Prevention: Always multiplex control files to at least 3 locations on different disks.

Q: Scenario: A developer deleted all rows from a production table by mistake and committed. How do you recover?

A: Option 1 — Flashback Table (fastest, if UNDO data still available): FLASHBACK TABLE orders TO TIMESTAMP TO_TIMESTAMP('2026-04-10 14:00:00','YYYY-MM-DD HH24:MI:SS'); This requires the UNDO_RETENTION parameter to have enough history. Option 2 — Flashback Query (if Flashback Table not possible): CREATE TABLE orders_backup AS SELECT * FROM orders AS OF TIMESTAMP TO_TIMESTAMP('2026-04-10 14:00:00','YYYY-MM-DD HH24:MI:SS'); Then: INSERT INTO orders SELECT * FROM orders_backup; COMMIT; Option 3 — RMAN Point-in-Time Recovery to a test environment, export the table, and import to production.

Q: Scenario: The database is running out of connections. Users get 'ORA-12520: TNS:listener could not find available handler'. How do you troubleshoot?

A: This means Oracle has reached its maximum connection limit. Steps: Step 1: Check current connections: SELECT count(*) FROM v$session; Step 2: Check max sessions parameter: SHOW PARAMETER sessions; Step 3: Look for idle or stale sessions: SELECT sid, serial#, username, status, last_call_et FROM v$session WHERE status = 'INACTIVE' AND last_call_et > 3600 ORDER BY last_call_et DESC. Step 4: Kill unnecessary sessions: ALTER SYSTEM KILL SESSION 'sid,serial#' IMMEDIATE; Step 5: Increase connection limits (if needed and resources allow): ALTER SYSTEM SET sessions = 500 SCOPE=SPFILE; Restart required. Step 6: Long-term: Implement connection pooling in the application layer.

💡 *Scenario answer structure: 1) Identify what error/symptom means. 2) Check views/logs to confirm root cause. 3) Immediate fix. 4) Verify fix worked. 5) Prevention / long-term solution.*

SECTION 14: High Availability — Combined Q&A

High Availability (HA) means keeping the database running even when hardware or software fails. As a mid-level DBA, you should understand the complete HA stack.

14.1 HA Comparison Table

Feature	Oracle RAC	Oracle Data Guard
Purpose	Multiple servers, one DB, load balancing	DR & HA via primary + standby DB
Location	Same data center	Different data centers (ideally)
Protects against	Node/server failure	Site failure, data corruption
Data loss on failover	None	Depends on protection mode
Standby usable?	N/A (all nodes are active)	Read-only (ADG for reads)
Oracle equivalent (SQL Server)	Failover Cluster Instances	AlwaysOn Availability Groups

14.2 HA Interview Q&A

Q: What is RTO and RPO? Why do DBAs need to know these?

A: RTO (Recovery Time Objective): How long the business can afford the system to be DOWN before it causes serious damage. Example: 'The bank's online portal must be back up within 30 minutes of any failure.' RPO (Recovery Point Objective): How much DATA LOSS the business can tolerate. Example: 'We cannot afford to lose more than 5 minutes of transaction data.' DBA's job: Design the HA/DR solution to meet the business's RTO and RPO. Low RTO + Zero RPO = Need RAC + Maximum Availability Data Guard + Active Data Guard. Higher RTO + Some data loss acceptable = Data Guard in Maximum Performance mode is enough.

Q: What is Oracle GoldenGate and how is it different from Data Guard?

A: GoldenGate is Oracle's advanced data replication tool. Differences from Data Guard: DATA GUARD: Replicates EVERYTHING from primary to standby. Standby must be on same Oracle version. Primarily for DR. GOLDENGATE: Can replicate specific tables, transforming data as it replicates. Can replicate between different databases (Oracle to MySQL, Oracle to SQL Server, etc.). Supports bi-directional replication (both databases can write). Used for: Data migrations, real-time data integration, cross-platform replication, and zero-downtime upgrades.

Q: Scenario: Primary Data Guard database went down. How do you perform a failover to standby?

A: Step 1: Confirm primary is truly down (not just a network issue): Try connecting to primary from standby server: sqlplus sys@primary. Step 2: On standby server, check standby status: SELECT database_role, open_mode FROM v$database; Step 3: Using Data Guard Broker: dgmgrl / DGMGRL> FAILOVER TO standby_db; (if FSFO is configured, this happens automatically) Step 4: Open the new primary database: ALTER DATABASE OPEN; Step 5: Update TNS/application connection strings to point to new primary. Step 6: Notify all application teams. Step 7: Plan rebuilding the old primary as a new standby.

🧠 **Memory Trick: RTO = Time to recover (get back online). RPO = Point of recovery (how much data lost). Lower both = more expensive HA solution needed.**

✔ RTO = max acceptable downtime. RPO = max acceptable data loss
✔ RAC = local HA (multiple nodes). Data Guard = remote DR (multiple sites)
✔ GoldenGate = logical replication across different platforms
✔ Failover = emergency, primary gone. Switchover = planned, graceful role change
✔ FSFO (Fast Start Failover) = automatic failover in Data Guard without DBA intervention

SECTION 15: Scenario-Based Q&A & Quick Revision

15.1 More Scenario Questions

Q: Scenario: How do you clone a production database to create a test/development copy?

A: Method 1 — RMAN Duplicate (most common): Take RMAN backup of production (or use active database). RMAN> DUPLICATE TARGET DATABASE TO devdb FROM ACTIVE DATABASE NOFILENAMECHECK SPFILE ... Method 2 — Data Pump Export/Import: Export specific schemas: expdp system/pass@PROD schemas=APP_SCHEMA dumpfile=app_prod.dmp logfile=expdp.log directory=DPUMP. Import to test: impdp system/pass@TEST remap_schema=APP_SCHEMA:APP_SCHEMA_TEST dumpfile=app_prod.dmp directory=DPUMP. Method 3 — Restore RMAN backup to new server with different DB name.

Q: Scenario: You need to upgrade Oracle from 12c to 19c with minimum downtime. What is your approach?

A: Option 1 — Data Guard Rolling Upgrade (minimum downtime): Set up a 19c standby for the 12c primary. Upgrade standby to 19c (primary stays 12c and running). Test standby. Switchover: 19c standby becomes new primary (downtime = just switchover time = minutes). Option 2 — DBUA (Database Upgrade Assistant): Schedule downtime window. Run DBUA which handles pre-checks, upgrade, post-checks. Option 3 — Transportable Tablespace or Data Pump: Export from 12c, import to fresh 19c. Pre-steps: Run pre-upgrade checks. Back up database. Test on non-production first. Check application compatibility. Post-steps: Run utlrp to fix invalid objects. Gather optimizer statistics.

Q: Scenario: An application team says their INSERT statements are very slow since yesterday. How do you troubleshoot?

A: Step 1: Get the slow SQL: SELECT sql_id, elapsed_time, executions, sql_text FROM v$sql WHERE sql_text LIKE '%INSERT%' ORDER BY elapsed_time DESC. Step 2: Check if there are locks on the target table: SELECT * FROM v$lock WHERE type = 'TM'. Step 3: Check undo tablespace — if undo is full, INSERTs slow down: Check dba_free_space for undo tablespace. Step 4: Check redo log size — if redo logs are too small and switching frequently (log file sync waits): SELECT * FROM v$log_history WHERE TRUNC(first_time) = TRUNC(SYSDATE-1) ORDER BY first_time. Step 5: Check for indexes on the table — too many indexes slow down INSERT since each insert must update all indexes. Step 6: Check if statistics need updating.

15.2 ⭐ TOP 20 Most Important Interview Questions — Quick List

Memorize these 20 questions before your interview!

- 1. What is the difference between Oracle Instance and Oracle Database?
- 2. What are the background processes in Oracle? (DBWR, LGWR, SMON, PMON, CKPT, ARCn)
- 3. What is SGA vs PGA?
- 4. What is ARCHIVELOG mode and why is it needed?
- 5. What is the difference between RESTORE and RECOVER?
- 6. What is RMAN and its advantages over manual backup?
- 7. How do you perform Point-in-Time Recovery?
- 8. What is Data Guard and what is the difference between Switchover and Failover?
- 9. What is RAC and how is it different from Data Guard?
- 10. What is an Undo Tablespace and why is it needed?
- 11. How do you unlock a database user account?
- 12. What is the difference between B-Tree and Bitmap index?
- 13. What are Wait Events? Name 5 common ones.
- 14. What is an AWR Report and how do you generate one?
- 15. How do you find blocking sessions and kill them?
- 16. What is the difference between Full, Incremental, and Differential backup?
- 17. What is a Hard Parse vs Soft Parse? How do bind variables help?
- 18. What are ACID properties in a database?
- 19. What is RTO and RPO?
- 20. How do you troubleshoot ORA-00257 (archive log destination full)?

15.3 Quick Revision Cheat Sheet

Key Oracle Views to Remember

View Name	What It Shows
V$DATABASE	Database name, open mode, archivelog mode
V$INSTANCE	Instance status, startup time
V$SESSION	All current sessions (who is connected)
V$SQL	Currently cached SQL statements
V$LOCKED_OBJECT	Objects that have active locks
V$ARCHIVED_LOG	History of archived log files
V$RMAN_BACKUP_JOB_DETAILS	RMAN backup history and status

DBA_USERS	All database users and their status
DBA_TABLESPACES	All tablespace definitions
DBA_DATA_FILES	Data files and their sizes
DBA_FREE_SPACE	Free space in tablespaces
DBA_OBJECTS	All database objects (status: VALID/INVALID)
DBA_SYS_PRIVS	System privileges granted to users/roles
DBA_TAB_PRIVS	Object privileges on tables
V$RECOVERY_FILE_DEST	FRA location and usage

15.4 Memory Tricks Summary

📝 *DBA Responsibilities: 'Users Store Back Tune' = User management, Storage, Backup, Tuning*

📝 *Physical Files: 'D-R-C' = Data files, Redo log files, Control files*

📝 *Logical Structure: 'Doctors Take Some Extra Breaks' = Database, Tablespace, Segment, Extent, Block*

📝 *Background Processes: 'Don't Let Students Play Computer Always' = DBWR, LGWR, SMON, PMON, CKPT, ARCn*

📝 *ACID: 'All Cats Ignore Dogs' = Atomicity, Consistency, Isolation, Durability*

📝 *Backup types: 'FID' = Full (everything), Incremental (since last ANY backup), Differential (since last FULL)*

📝 *Restore vs Recover: Restore = copy files back. Recover = apply redo logs to make current*

📝 *Switchover vs Failover: Switch = Planned (like a scheduled flight). Failover = Emergency (like an evacuation)*

15.5 Final Interview Tips

💡 *Start answers with: 'In my experience...' or 'The way I approach this...' — it sounds more confident.*

💡 *For scenario questions: Always mention a STEP-BY-STEP approach. Interviewers love structured thinking.*

💡 *When you don't know something: Say 'I haven't encountered that specific scenario, but my approach would be...' — never make up an answer.*

💡 *Mention real tools: AWR, ADDM, RMAN, OEM, Data Guard Broker (DGMGRL), SSMS. Using tool names shows real experience.*

💡 *End scenario answers with a prevention tip: 'To prevent this in future, I would set up monitoring alerts / autoextend / RMAN retention policy...'*

💡 *Ask one smart question at the end: 'What is the current Oracle version in your environment and are you planning to migrate to cloud Oracle (OCI/RDS)?'*